

The following article was taken from the March 27, 1924 issue of the **PAULDING DEMOCRAT. MORE ON EARLY HISTORY OF COUNTY--** Mrs. Pursel Gives Interesting Narrative On Early Days-- Dating back to 1850.

In a recent issue of the Democrat appeared an article written by the proprietor, in which he recounted conditions generally, as he found them in Paulding and Paulding County when he first came here in 1879. Also referring to citizens who were prominent here at that time.

There are many citizens of the county who came here at a still earlier date, among them being Mrs. A.M. Pursel, of Paulding, who has kindly contributed an article on its early history, which is given here-with, for which she has the thanks of this newspaper, and which will no doubt be read with much interest:

Mr. Webster, of the Paulding Democrat gives us a little sketch of Paulding County history, beginning with the year 1879. I came to Paulding a little girl of five or six years, in 1850, when the county seat was moved from Charloe to this place.

We came by way of the old Anthony Wayne and Fort Defiance road, it being the only wagon road between those two points.

I can only remember the names of five families that were living here at that time, Campbells, Torrys, Hickersons, and Kohns, all from Van Wert:Shafers from Indiana, and Judge Latty from Charloe, The Van Wert road was cut through the solid woods, and as I remember it several years later was badly grown up to sprouts from tree stumps.

Most traveling was done on horse back.

Paulding county was full of wild game. Deer, squirrel, coon and occasionally, a big black bear was killed. We could hear the howling of wolves at night and they would run the dogs up to the door. There was also an abundance of lovely fish in Flat Rock. There was no scarcity of wild turkeys; mother would cut out the breast, slice, and fry it, boil the rest and feed it to the dogs. We used the tails for fans and the wings for dusters.

At that time coon dogs were in demand. Fur buyers made regular trips from Indiana to Defiance, always on horseback, and leading an extra horse with a great pack of coon skins hanging from each side of the horse, and a large roll of deer hides across the top. There was no scarcity of fresh meat at that time.

The little run back of Robert Wheeler's home used to be called a "Deer Lick", because deer came there to drink. Salt was sprinkled near the water and many a deer gave it's life for a lick of salt.

The first term of court was held in our house (the first house put up in Paulding). Judge Latty presiding. Our first court house was a two story frame building, with court rooms on the upper room for it was there the ladies served a dinner for our soldiers when home on furlough. That building was burned and later

the second building was put up, and the brick offices were built.

We had a jail standing on the ground now occupied by the present court house. It was built of heavy hewed timber, the door of heavy planks and driven full of iron spikes. On the outside, to the west, a stairway was built. The home guards during the Civil war kept their guns and ammunition, which was used for drilling and practice, in that upper room of the jail.

During the Civil war, or at least a part of that time, we got our mail from Charloe by sending a man either on horseback or on foot through the seven miles of dense forest. The Charloe pike was at that time what we called a blazed trail, made by chipping the bark from each side of a tree. The mail came by canal boat from Cincinnati and was brought here by some one volunteering to make the trip, everyone being anxious to get letters from our soldiers.

The first settlers had the ague and mosquitoes to contend with, and our nearest doctor was B.B. Woodcock, from the reservoir. I can't remember whether we sent for him or whether he made regular trips through the county. Nevertheless, he was always on hand with his quinine and pills.

All of "Dixie" at that time was a swamp, covered with water, and rotten moss covered logs, which accounts for its richness of soil. And the "music" of the great big green bull frogs was just wonderful. Too bad they were not used for food, when there were so many of them.

By 1855? or 1866? (sorry, I can't make the date out) there were a number of good families in Paulding: Frenches, Richards, Cables, Reeds, Merigs, Smiths, Strothers, Shannons, Savages, Russells, McCrearies, Nortons, and many others, mostly young married people, full of life and ambition, just the kind to build up a new town. Later came the Crawfords, ? and three families of Barnes, all farmers and a grand help to our county.

Our roads most of the year, especially during the wet season, were in bad shape, covered with water and mud. People would get as far as Six Mile by wagon and then make the rest of the way on foot to Emerald station by walking on logs at one side of the road. Tate's Landing and Junction were lively places at that time. Each had a hotel, dry goods stores and groceries, and we used to go there to do some of our buying. There were two churches at Junction, Catholic and Methodist. Several of us went to the dedication of the M.E. church, went horseback. It seems to me like a dream that is past. If there is any one living that was at the dedication I would love to hear from them.

A saw mill which stood on the creek at the south end of main street had been built by Van Wert parties when the county seat was first moved here. Father bought it and later added a grist mill, which was a great help to people who had been

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obliged to take their grain to other places. A deep wide waste way had been dug from the dam to the mill and we always had a good canoe, and we children spent many happy hours fishing for sun fish and paddling in the water. It would take a wonderful stretch of the imagination at the present time to see that end of town as it looked more than sixty years ago. It may be that I am the only one that has lived to see every improvement that has been made in this town and county. Not many of the old friends of my childhood are left.

Since 1879 many changes have been made. Good business rooms, good churches and good sidewalks have been built, and the automobile is fast taking the place of the faithful horse. A.M.P.

Amanda M. Shafer married Valentine V. Purcell on July 21 1867, she was born on Feb. 2 1845, and died April 16, 1927, and is buried in Paulding's Live Oak Cemetery. In the 1880 Census Amanda's occupation is listed as Hat Store, and her husband, Valentine is listed, farmer. They had four children, Jesse L. daughter age 11, Frank V. age 10, Ruby E. age 7, Carl age 4. In the 1860 Census, Amanda is living with Elias Shafer and Sivinia, their other children are Christopher 15 and Roxanna A. 13.

CORRECTION in the EARLY MARRIAGES OF PAULDING COUNTY, OHIO by Ray Keck. John CAMPBELL married Lydia HARRELL, not HAMELL, as stated in the book., according to PAULINE ENGDAHL, 3724 ST. JOSEPH ST. SOUTH BEND, IN. 46614-1858.

Last summer, the CLARK CEMETERY was re-read, there were some mistakes in the CEMETERY BOOK listings found. If anyone would like the revised list, please send a large SASE to the club. This cemetery is between Antwerp and Hicksville, on St. Rt. 49.

The following poem was submitted by Betty Wilson.

Ten Thousand Forebears March within my blood
Their life streams merge, And lift mine to his flood,
My heart, be swift and steadfast, bold and true:
Ten Thousand hearts have put their faith in you. Author-- Elinor Lennon

There are ten CEMETERY BOOK-1986 compiled by Ray Keck, left. If you would like one, please hurry.

The Paulding County Historical Society, still has reprints of the PAULDING COUNTY HISTORICAL ATLAS 1892 available. They are selling them for \$10, \$2.91 Post.
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